

A FREE MINI MYSTERY FROM A MAISON SOIRÉE

The Wet Half-Hour

A murder mystery for exactly four players · 45 minutes · print and play

Four people. Eleven printed documents. Forty-five minutes at a kitchen table. One of the four of you killed Edmund Rook, and none of you knows which.

WHAT YOU NEED

A printer, a pair of scissors, four pencils and four people. Print the whole file. Two of the pages hold the four suspect cards, two to a page, with a dashed “cut here” line across the middle: cut those into four. Keep the rest in three piles. That is the whole setup, and it takes about ten minutes.

THE FIVE RULES THIS GAME IS BUILT ON

- Nothing is memorised. Your card is a reference sheet you read off when somebody asks you something.
 - Nothing is read aloud in character. No accents, no costumes, no acting, anywhere.
 - Nobody lies. Every word on every card is true. What misleads you is what a card leaves out.
 - Nobody knows they are the culprit — including the culprit. You will all find out together.
 - The paper carries the whole solution. Every fact you need is printed on a document that sits on the table. The four of you are the fast route, not the only one.
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The answer is not in this file. It is in a second file called THE ANSWER. Do not open that one until the ballots are counted — whoever is hosting can play too, because nothing in these pages tells you who did it.

musolanto-hash.github.io/a-maison-soiree-guides

How To Play

THE CASE

The Juniper Inn, in the village of Wren's Hollow. Tuesday the 4th of November, a wet afternoon. The inn is shut between lunch and six.

In August a debt collector called Edmund Rook bought the mortgage on the inn from the bank, and has been coming for the money in person ever since. He came again this afternoon, at twenty to four. At five past four he went down the cellar stairs with a lamp to count the stock that secures the note.

At eight minutes to five the coal merchant tipped a sack down the chute, came round to the hatch steps, and found Mr Rook at the bottom of them with the cellar door-weight beside him and his wallet open.

Four people were in the building or the yard. All four of them are sitting at this table.

HOW THE EVENING RUNS

- Deal the four cards face down and take one each without choosing. Read your own card. Do not read anybody else's, and do not hand it over.
- ROUND ONE (12 minutes). Put out documents C-1, C-2 and C-3. Read them out loud, or pass them round. Then ask each other questions. You answer from your card. If the card does not cover it, the honest answer is "I don't remember", and that is a legal answer printed on all four cards.
- ROUND TWO (15 minutes). Put out C-4 to C-9. These are the papers. This is the round where the why arrives, and it is the longest one.
- ROUND THREE (10 minutes). Put out C-10 and C-11. These are the measurements. If your table has been arguing well, this round ends the argument.
- THE BALLOT (5 minutes). Everyone fills in an accusation slip, including the person they think it is, and the one fact they would hang it on. Fold them. Then, and only then, open THE ANSWER.

TWO THINGS WORTH KNOWING BEFORE YOU START

You may accuse yourself. People do, and they are sometimes right.

There is no lie-detecting in this game, so there is nothing to adjudicate and nobody has to be a referee. You are not trying to catch somebody out. You are trying to work out which of four true stories has a hole in the middle of it.

HOST SHEET · CONTAINS NO SPOILERS

For Whoever Is Printing

You can read every word of this and still play.

You can read every word of this page and still sit down and play. Nothing here says who did it, and nothing in the eleven documents says it either — the solution has to be assembled, which is why the host can hold a card like everybody else.

PRINTING

- Print at 100% “Actual size”, not “fit to page”. Every page in this file is laid out to fall inside both US Letter and A4 without scaling.
- The two pages marked “cut here” are the four suspect cards, two to a page. Cut along the dashed line.
- Everything prints legibly in black and white on the cheapest paper in the house. Nothing in this file is set smaller than 11 point and no text sits on top of a picture.

SETTING UP, TEN MINUTES

- Make three piles: C-1 to C-3, C-4 to C-9, C-10 and C-11. Put the second and third out of sight.
- Four accusation slips and four pencils on the table.
- Put the sheet marked WHAT WE KNOW in the middle where everyone can write on it.
- Set a phone alarm for 12, then 15, then 10 minutes. The alarms run the evening, not you.

THE ONLY FOUR THINGS YOU SAY OUT LOUD

Read these as yourself. There is no character for the host and nothing to perform.

AT THE START — “Edmund Rook came here this afternoon for money. At eight minutes to five he was found at the bottom of the cellar steps. The four of us were in the building. One of us did it, and the honest truth is that none of us knows which — that is how this one is built. Everything on your card is true. Nobody is lying to anybody tonight.”

AT ROUND TWO — “These are the papers. The constable took them off Rook's desk in Aldersbury on Wednesday morning, so nobody in this room got to tidy them first.”

AT ROUND THREE — “This is what the constable measured, and he says plainly that he is making no accusation. We are.”

AT THE BALLOT — “Name somebody, and name the one thing on paper you would hang it on. You may name yourself. Fold it over. Nobody reads these until the end.”

THE FOUR QUESTIONS YOU WILL ACTUALLY BE ASKED

- “Can I lie?” No. Nobody in this game lies. If your card does not cover it, say you don't remember.
- “Am I allowed to show somebody my card?” No — but you may read any line of it out loud, and you may read the whole thing out loud if you want to.
- “What if I think it's me?” Say so. It may be. Write your own name on the ballot if you believe it.
- “What if we get it wrong?” Then you get it wrong. The reveal tells you which document you walked past.

IF YOU ARE THREE, OR FIVE

At three: leave out Dr Quill's card and read it aloud as a written statement instead — everything on it also appears on a document. At five: the fifth person takes the accusation slips, keeps the time, and reads out THE ANSWER at the end, which is the best job at the table.

S1 Mrs Harriet Pell

52 · keeps the Juniper Inn

The inn was your mother's. In August a man called Edmund Rook bought the mortgage off the bank and started coming for the money in person, which the bank never did.

You are clear of it. At the end of October you drew £412 out of the post office savings — every penny you had — and gave it to Mr Bram to carry to Rook. On the 2nd Mr Bram told you it was done.

Rook came anyway this afternoon, at twenty to four, and would not say why. At four o'clock you told Mr Bram, in the hall, that Rook had gone down to count the barrels. At ten past you bolted the pantry stair door on your side, because the draught up that stair takes the flour off the table.

You were alone in the kitchen from twenty past four until a quarter to five, with the yard door propped open for the steam. You did not go down to the cellar.

One of the four of you did it, and your card will not tell you which, because nobody knows. Everything here is true; nothing here is the whole evening. "I don't remember" is a legal answer.

cut here

S2 Mr Silas Bram

44 · bookkeeper, at the inn on Tuesdays

You keep the books for the Juniper, the garage, and the two farms at Hollow End.

On the 31st of October Mrs Pell gave you £412 in notes, in the office, to carry to Mr Rook against the note. You wrote her a line for it. On the 2nd you told her it was settled and that the discharge would come by post.

This afternoon you booked a trunk call from the front desk at eighteen minutes past four and cleared it at half past. It was to Aldersbury and it was about Mr Rook, and you would rather not repeat it in front of everybody.

You went out into the yard once, after the call, to see whether the coal had come. You came back into the house by the front door, because the carter's horse was in the lane and it is a nervous animal.

You did not speak to Mr Rook after three o'clock.

One of the four of you did it, and your card will not tell you which, because nobody knows. Everything here is true; nothing here is the whole evening. "I don't remember" is a legal answer.

S3 Miss Nell Fisk

19 · yard hand

You do the coal, the crates, the bottles and the horse. You have worked here since you were fifteen, and Mrs Pell taught you to read.

You were in the yard all afternoon and your boots are still wet. The Birchfield cart came to the lane gate at twenty-six minutes past four, in the rain, and you signed for two crates and a sack. The carter stood under the gate until the rain went over, and you held the horse's head the whole time, because he will not stand for thunder.

You knew Mr Rook by sight and you did not like him. In September he stopped you in the yard and asked you what the cellar held, and whether Mrs Pell kept the key on her.

You did not go down the hatch today. You did not go into the house between four and five.

One of the four of you did it, and your card will not tell you which, because nobody knows. Everything here is true; nothing here is the whole evening. "I don't remember" is a legal answer.

cut here

S4 Dr Ambrose Quill

71 · retired physician, room 2 since March

You have lived in room 2 since March, and you would like to go on living in it.

In September you asked Mr Rook, in the snug, what he would take for the freehold of the inn. He laughed at you and named a figure, and you wrote the figure down. You have not mentioned any of this to Mrs Pell.

This afternoon you were in your chair by the window. The chambermaid took your linen out at a quarter past four and brought it back pressed at twenty to five, and you asked her the time.

You heard the rain start and you heard it stop. Some time after it stopped, and before the girl came back with the linen, you heard somebody cross the yard below your window. Your window is at the back, over the coal hatch. You did not look out, because you were reading, and because people cross that yard all day.

One of the four of you did it, and your card will not tell you which, because nobody knows. Everything here is true; nothing here is the whole evening. "I don't remember" is a legal answer.

WREN'S HOLLOW CONSTABULARY

C-1

Report of the scene

Made by Constable A. Dorrit, 4 November, at the Juniper Inn. Timed from the kitchen clock, which the stationmaster checked against the station clock on Wednesday and found correct.

Called out at 4.55 p.m. by Mr J. Pryor, coal merchant. Arrived 5.02 p.m.

THE BODY. Mr Edmund Rook, 58, of Aldersbury. Lying on the brick floor of the cellar at the foot of the six steps that come down beside the coal chute, face down, feet towards the steps. One blow to the back of the head. No other mark on him. Dr Quill, who lodges here, says one blow and death within a minute or two of it, and that he could not put an hour to it closer than the afternoon.

THE WEAPON. The cellar door-weight, six pounds of iron on a cord, which hangs on a hook beside the inner door and pulls it shut. It was on the floor a foot from his head. The cord is frayed through where it has been pulled off its hook rather than lifted off.

THE LAMP. A hurricane lamp, lit, standing upright on a barrel three feet from him, with oil in it. Whoever was down there had light.

THE TWO WAYS IN. (1) The pantry stair, through a door at the head of it. That door was bolted on the pantry side. Mrs Pell shot the bolt at ten past four and drew it at five to five when Mr Pryor shouted up from the yard; Mr Pryor was at the hatch and heard her draw it. (2) The coal hatch in the yard, with six brick steps beside the chute. The hatch was open. It is never locked.

THE FLOOR. The cellar floor is dry brick and has been dry for a week. There is one line of damp prints on it, coming down from the hatch steps to the body and going back to the hatch steps. There are no damp prints anywhere else in the cellar and none at all on the pantry stair. I have put the measurements of them on a separate sheet.

THE WALLET. Open, beside his right hand. Four pockets in it. Three folded buff forms in it: the note itself, the demand dated 1 November, and a receipt for £40 part payment dated 14 October. All three are folded with the printed side turned in. His clerk at Aldersbury says he folds them the other way, printed side out, and has done for nine years, and that Mr Rook never refolded anything in his life.

His money was in his breast pocket and was not touched. £18 and some silver.

WREN'S HOLLOW STATION HOUSE

C-2

Rainfall and weather book

Kept hourly by the stationmaster. Entry for 4 November.

Fine and cold to 4.20 p.m. Rain, heavy, from 4.20 p.m. to 4.35 p.m., 0.31 in. Clear after, no more rain that night.

Note added by the stationmaster at the constable's request, 5 November: "The lane and the yard behind the Juniper stood in water until about ten past five. The gutter at the north-east corner of the inn comes down on the cobbles right by the coal hatch, and there were two or three inches of water standing against that wall all evening. Anybody crossing that corner after the rain went through it, whether they wanted to or not."

E. ROOK, COLLECTIONS — ALDERSBURY

C-3

Flyleaf of the collecting book

In Mr Rook's own hand. He wrote this list every morning. Taken from his desk by the constable, 5 November.

4th Nov. Wren's Hollow, the Juniper. In the wallet, four papers, all buff, all folded in three, and there is no telling one from another until you open it:

1. The note.
2. The demand, 1 Nov.
3. Receipt, £40 on account, 14 Oct.
4. Letter to Mrs H. Pell. Sealed. To be put in her own hand and not left with anybody.

■ *Three of the four were in the wallet when he was found. The fourth was not.*

THE JUNIPER INN

C-4

The day book

Mrs Pell's hand. Four entries, with a slip of paper pinned below the second.

29 Oct — Mr Bram says the bank's man will take the whole in cash and be done with it. Went to the post office savings and drew £412, being all of it.

31 Oct — Gave Mr Bram £412 in notes, in the office, to carry to Mr Rook at Aldersbury on Friday. Mr Bram wrote me a line for it and I have pinned it here.

Received of Mrs H. Pell four hundred and twelve pounds, to be paid over to Mr E. Rook against the Juniper note. — S. Bram, 31 October

2 Nov — Mr Bram says it is done and the discharge will come by post.

3 Nov — No post. Asked Mr Bram again. He says Mr Rook is slow with paper.

E. ROOK, COLLECTIONS — ALDERSBURY

C-5

Press copy of a letter

Mr Rook kept a damp press copy of every letter he wrote. This is the copy of the letter he sealed and carried to Wren's Hollow on the 4th. Taken from the copy book on his desk, 5 November.

The Bell Hotel, Aldersbury. 3rd November.

Madam,

I am obliged to write to you plainly, and I would rather do it on paper than across a table.

You have twice said to me, and once in the hearing of my clerk, that four hundred and twelve pounds was paid over to me on the 2nd of this month by Mr Bram on your behalf, and that a discharge was to follow by post.

No such sum has been paid to me. Not on the 2nd, not on any other day, not at this house and not at my office. I have issued no discharge, because there was nothing to discharge. I hold the note and I hold it unsatisfied, and the demand falls due on Friday.

I do not say where your money is. I say only that it is not with me, and that you should ask Mr Bram for it in front of a witness, and that you should do it this week.

I shall be at the Inn on Tuesday afternoon. I will not send this by post. I will put it in your hand myself and wait while you read it.

Your obedient servant, EDMUND ROOK.

Constable's note: Mrs Pell has never seen this letter. I read it to her on the Wednesday and she had to sit down.

POST OFFICE TELEPHONES — WREN'S HOLLOW EXCHANGE

C-6

Trunk call ticket

One ticket is written for every trunk call and kept at the exchange for the quarter's accounts.

FROM	Wren's Hollow 14 — the Juniper Inn, front desk
BOOKED BY	Mr S. Bram
TO	Aldersbury 227
CONNECTED	4.18 p.m.
CLEARED	4.33 p.m.
CHARGEABLE	15 minutes
DATE	4 November

Operator's note: "The gentleman asked me to keep trying. I put him through at the second attempt."

THE BELL HOTEL, ALDERSBURY · TELEPHONE ALDERSBURY 227

C-7

Letter to the constable

5 November. In answer to a letter from Constable Dorrit sent the same morning.

Sir — In answer to yours of this morning.

Mr Edmund Rook has not stayed in this house since September, though he takes his letters here and writes in our coffee room most Mondays, and everybody in Aldersbury knows it.

No money was paid to Mr Rook in this house on the 2nd of November, or at any time this autumn. I can be certain of that, because money paid to Mr Rook is handed in at our desk and entered in the desk book against his name, and there is no entry.

Yesterday, Tuesday, at about twenty past four, a gentleman telephoned from Wren's Hollow and asked my desk clerk twice over whether Mr Rook had “settled up on Monday”, and then whether there was “anything in the book at all” against his name. My clerk told him exactly what I have told you. The gentleman rang off without leaving a name and did not ask for Mr Rook.

Yours faithfully, J. MARCHMONT, Manager.

THE JUNIPER INN

C-8

Two household books

The laundry round book, kept by Ivy Sallow, chambermaid. And the kitchen book, in Mrs Pell's hand.

Laundry round, 4 November

Room 1 — 4.05, linen out. Room empty.

Room 2 — 4.15, linen out. Doctor in his chair by the window. 4.40, pressed linen back in. Doctor in the same chair with the same book. He asked me the time and I said twenty to five.

Room 4 — 4.45, linen out. Room empty.

Kitchen book, 4 November

4.20 — six loaves out. 4.44 — eight loaves in, oven at full. 5.20 — out.

BIRCHFIELD & SON, CARRIERS

C-9

Delivery ticket

Delivery to the Juniper Inn, 4 November, with the carter's note written on the back the next morning at the constable's request.

DELIVERED	2 crates, 1 sack
WHERE	At the lane gate, not carried in
RECEIVED BY	N. Fisk
TIME SIGNED	4.26 p.m.

On the back: "Rain came on hard as I turned into the lane. I stood under the gate with the girl till it went over and got away at 4.44 by my own watch. She never went in the whole time. She was at the horse's head, because he won't stand for thunder and there was thunder in it. — W. Birchfield, carter."

WREN'S HOLLOW CONSTABULARY

C-10

The measurements

Constable A. Dorrit's second sheet. Prints taken 5.05 p.m. Footwear measured 5.15 p.m., everybody present and watching.

The damp prints on the cellar floor

One line of them, from the foot of the hatch steps to the body and back again. Nothing anywhere else. The print measures $9\frac{1}{4}$ inches heel to toe and 3 inches across the ball. Smooth leather sole with a stitched welt — the stitching prints as a broken line about three-eighths of an inch in from the edge. On the right foot there is a crescent of wear on the outer edge of the heel, about an inch across, and it prints every time.

Every pair of shoes in the house

WHOSE	WHAT THEY HAD ON	LENGTH	THE SOLE
Mrs H. Pell	House shoes, on since morning. Dry inside and out.	$9\frac{1}{2}$ in	Smooth sole, no welt stitching. Heel worn square across. No crescent.
Mr S. Bram	Town shoes. Damp across the toe and along the welt. His rubber overshoes are not on the hall stand and he cannot say where he left them.	$9\frac{1}{4}$ in	Smooth sole, stitched welt. Crescent of wear on the outer edge of the right heel, one inch.
Miss N. Fisk	Rubber yard boots, wet through.	$11\frac{1}{2}$ in	Cleated rubber. No welt.
Dr A. Quill	Carpet slippers, worn indoors. His outdoor boots are on the hall rack, dry, and the laces are tied in a bow with dust lying across the knot.	Slippers 10 in · boots $10\frac{1}{4}$ in	Slippers felt. Boots crepe. No welt on either.
Mr J. Pryor	Boots, wet. He came in by the hatch at 4.52 and went no further than the steps.	12 in	Cleated. No welt.

C-10 · The measurements (continued)

WHOSE	WHAT THEY HAD ON	LENGTH	THE SOLE
The house's spare yard shoes	On the scullery shelf. Dry. Dust undisturbed on the shelf around them.	9 in	Wooden-soled clogs. No welt, no heel.

I make no accusation in this sheet. I have set down what I measured, and I have measured everything there was.

WREN'S HOLLOW CONSTABULARY

C-11

The yard and the hall stand

Constable A. Dorrit's third sheet, 4 November, 5.30 p.m., and the Saturday dusting checked with Mrs Sallow on the 5th.

1. At the top of the hatch steps, against the north-east wall of the yard, standing side by side and upright: a pair of men's rubber overshoes, the size that goes over a 9 or a 10 shoe. Both of them full of water to the brim. The gutter comes down eighteen inches above them.
2. The hall stand in the front passage has four pegs and a boot rail. Dr Quill's boots are on the rail, dry. Next to them there is a clean oval on the rail, free of dust, eleven inches by four, where a pair of overshoes has stood since Mrs Sallow last dusted the rail on Saturday.
3. The garden gate at the far side of the yard, which gives on to the lane above the gate the carter was standing under, was open. The wet grass beyond it is trodden in one direction only — away from the yard, towards the lane.
4. Nobody in the house owns a second pair of overshoes and nobody claims these.

CUT INTO FOUR · ONE EACH

The Accusation Slip

Fill it in before anybody opens the answer. You may name yourself.

THE JUNIPER INN · 4 NOVEMBER

I say it was _____

The one fact on paper I would hang it on _____

The document it is printed on (C-) _____

I could not clear _____

Signed _____

THE JUNIPER INN · 4 NOVEMBER

I say it was _____

The one fact on paper I would hang it on _____

The document it is printed on (C-) _____

I could not clear _____

Signed _____

THE JUNIPER INN · 4 NOVEMBER

I say it was _____

The one fact on paper I would hang it on _____

The document it is printed on (C-) _____

I could not clear _____

Signed _____

THE JUNIPER INN · 4 NOVEMBER

I say it was _____

The one fact on paper I would hang it on _____

The document it is printed on (C-) _____

I could not clear _____

Signed _____

KEEP THIS ONE IN THE MIDDLE OF THE TABLE

What We Know

Fill it in together. Everybody writes on it.

WHEN could it have happened? (C-1, C-2)

HOW did whoever it was get into the cellar? (C-1)

WHICH of the four papers is missing, and how do we know? (C-1, C-3)

WHAT did that paper say? (C-5)

WHO is cleared between 4.20 and 4.52, and by which document?

WHO could have made the print? (C-10)

WHOSE overshoes are at the hatch? (C-10, C-11)

THE ONE FACT we would hang it on:
